

Jaguar M270S

Mobility for a pittance

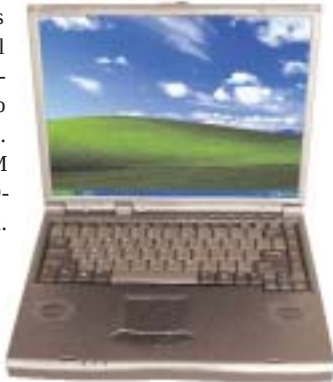
The Jaguar M270S clones the ACi Ethos4 in all aspects. The only distinguishing factor between the two is the colour of the plastic used.

It offers only a Pentium 4 M 1.7 GHz, 256 MB of RAM, a CD-ROM drive and 20 GB hard disk. The SiS 650 chipset provides an onboard graphics adapter. The small 13.3-inch TFT LCD was crisp and clear.

Looks-wise, the M270S is no different from the Ethos4, but the use of the colour brown, imparts some appeal. The keyboard layout is quite cramped, but the keys provide positive tactile feedback. The touchpad is sensitive and accurate, but the entrenched buttons are a pain to use.

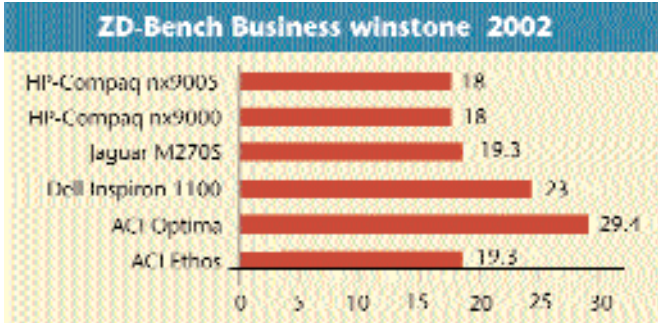
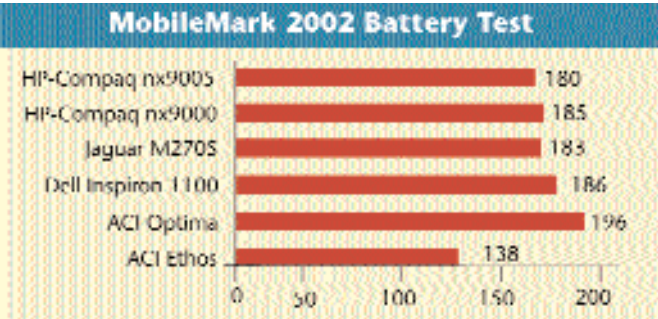
Owing to a slow processor, it finished last in the CPU tests. However, the memory sub-system is quite brilliant, and managed to beat the ACi Optima by a small margin. The hard disk subsystem is a complete mess and its scores are the lowest. It yielded a pathetic frame rate while playing *Quake III Arena* and could hardly be used for graphics-intensive tasks.

If you are looking for a laptop to make presentations and work with Word processors and Excel sheets, the M270S is a good buy at just Rs 55,000—the second cheapest in our comparison.



Price: Rs 55,000
+ Decent looks
- Low features and performance

Jaguar M270S	C+
Performance	▲ ▲ ▲ ▲ ▲
Features	▲ ▲ ▲ ▲ ▲
Usability	▲ ▲ ▲ ▲ ▲
Value for money	▲ ▲ ▲ ▲ ▲



History of Laptops

1970s: Alan Kay, of the Xerox Palo Alto Research Center, California, builds the Dynabook that can handle most computing needs, and has wireless network capabilities.

1979: William Moggridge designs the Grid Compass. It has a 340 KB bubble memory, a die-cast magnesium case and a folding electro-luminescent graphics display.

1981: A book publisher, Adam Osborne, comes up with the Osborne 1. With a 5-inch screen, modem port, two 5.25-inch drives, a battalion software and a battery pack. It weighs almost 11 Kgs and costs \$1795 (about Rs 86,000). The Epson HX-20—a battery-powered portable computer, with a 20-character by 4-line LCD display and built-in printer—is also released.

1983: Gavilan Computer—it has 64 KB RAM, a Gavilan operating system (also runs MS-DOS), an 8088 microprocessor, touch-pad mouse, portable printer and weighs 4 Kgs—6.4 Kgs with the printer. Radio Shack also releases the TRS-80 Model 100. Microsoft wrote its ROM programs—Bill Gates wrote a few himself! It uses standard AA batteries.

1984: IBM announces the IBM 5155 Portable Personal Computer—equipped with 640K RAM, two double-sided 5.25-inch drives, and an amber monochrome monitor. Apple also launches the Apple IIc model—a notebook-sized computer that had a 65C02 microprocessor, 128 kilobytes of memory, an internal 5.25-inch floppy drive, two serial ports, a mouse port, modem card, external power supply, and a folding handle.

1986: IBM introduces its IBM PC Convertible. It uses an 8088 microprocessor, has 256 kilobytes of memory, two 3.5-inch floppy drives, an LCD, parallel and serial printer ports and a space for an internal modem. It came with its own applications software, weighed 5.4 Kg and sold for \$3,500 (about Rs 1,68,000).

Conclusion

The mainstream category was completely dominated by models from two vendors, namely HP Compaq and ACi, with each of them sending in two models. Despite their relative similarity in terms of hardware configuration, the HP Compaq models were distinctively different from the rest of the crowd; in fact they were the best looking laptops in the comparison with unmatched aesthetic appeal.

The ACi Ethos4 is targeted at the low-end market and provides reasonably good hardware, but lacks style and scores low on the appeal. The Jaguar is a complete copy of the Ethos4, with just different colour and body panels. Both these laptops are a complete no-no if you like some flair. The ACi Optima is based on the Centrino platform and offers better features, but like its low-end sibling, lacks sophistication when it comes to looks. The Dell Inspiron 1100 looked great, and performed even better.

In terms of features, the HP Compaq nx9000 beat most of the laptops hands down, its aggressive yet sophisticated styling helped it take the top honours for this category. We had no doubt about it being the winner—It had the right mix of the required ingredients.

While the Dell Inspiron and ACi Optima did exceptionally better than the HP Compaq in pure performance, they lost to the nx9000 on all the remaining factors. The HP Compaq nx9005 claimed the value for money title with its good looks, decent performance and pricing. Overall, HP Compaq swept clean all the titles in this category.